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About the Author



William Shakespeare (1564 – 1616), an English poet and playwright is widely regarded as the greatest writer in English language and the world's pre-eminent dramatist. He was born and brought up in Stratford-upon-Avon, Warwickshire. He wrote about 39 plays, 154 sonnets, two long narrative poems, and a few other verses. He was often called England's National Poet and nicknamed the Bard of Avon. The first publishing of Shakespeare's works is the '*The First Folio*'. Playwright Ben Johnson wrote a preface to this book including the quote '(Shakespeare) is not of an age, but for all time.' His plays have been translated into every major living language and are constantly studied and performed throughout the world.

Glossary

epitaph – short pieces of writing inscribed on tombstones in memory of the dead

executors – persons who put someone's terms of will into effect

bequeath – pass on something to the next generation by means of a will

deposed – removed from office or power

slain – killed

antic – someone who draws attention through silly or funny acts (here a court jester)

scoffing – expressing mockery

grinning – smiling wildly

monarchize – rule , carry out the duties and functions of a ruler

impregnable – impossible to pass through

ceremonious – being very formal

Explanation:

Lines 1-3 :

When King Richard abdicates his throne and surrenders the political control of England to the rebellious Henry Bolingbroke, he desperately realises the mortality of kings. 'Dust' is compared to paper and 'Rainy eyes' to writing instruments.

Line 9 :

'small model of the barren earth' - the body's flesh stands for all perishable things - here a "model" of the "barren earth

Line 16:

hollow crown - the crown is empty in the middle and this connotes that power is not solid or strong or permanent

Line 18 :

'there the antic sits... farewell king' - here Death is portrayed as a court jester who grants the mortal kings, the temporary licence to 'monarchise'.